heightened in India and a ‘new form of ethno-political majoritarianism delinked from religious Hindu nationalism was key to the party’s ability to attract new voters’.[19]

This return to core ideological principles is a strategy that the RSS had long recommended. In fact, each time the BJP lost elections in the past, the RSS had publicly argued that the reason was a dilution of ideology. After the party finished poorly in the UP assembly election of 2007, for example, the *Organiser* editor R. Balashankar wrote a signed piece, arguing that the ‘BJP lost steam midway. Its campaign got stuck between half-hearted Hindutva and development governance. An aggressive Hindutva approach would have ensured greater success … but the party was extremely restrained.’[20] The same happened in 2004. After Vajpayee’s surprise loss, an RSS spokesperson told the media, ‘The BJP has lost its way because it abandoned Hindutva’.[21]

Vajpayee’s early 1980s experiment with turning the BJP into the ‘asli [real] Janata Party’ had ended in failure. Writing scathingly of that experiment, former Jan Sangh president Balraj Madhok wrote that the BJP ‘adopted its two-coloured flag and Gandhian socialism as its ideology and claimed the Jan Sangh whose name, saffron flag and ideology it discarded’. That gambit ended in the party being reduced to two seats in the Lok Sabha in 1984. The BJP returned to its core issues of Ayodhya, Kashi and Mathura thereafter: temple issues Madhok said he had first raised in the Lok Sabha on 30 September 1961. Juxtaposing the ebbs and flows of the BJP’s electoral fortunes with the embrace and distancing of its core ideological principles, Madhok argued that there could only be one conclusion:[22]

This partial return to the Jan Sangh brought rich dividends to the BJP. Its tally in the Lok Sabha rose from two to 86 in the 1989 general election, to 121 in 1991 and to 163 in the 1996 election. However it began to distance itself from the Jan Sangh ideology after 1996 in search of new allies to enable it to form a government. Its decline had begun. In the 1998 elections, it could win only 180 seats and its growth rate came down to zero in the 1999 poll. There is now